

FROM CAREERS TO CHOICE



44%

of employees globally thriving at work, down sharply from **66%** in 2024



74%

value purpose-driven work in India, but **54%** are ready to leave for better pay, showing a purpose-pay tension



45%

prioritise flexibility, **46%** prioritise positive workplace culture

SOURCE MERCER'S GLOBAL TALENT TRENDS 2026

consulting, freelancing or portfolio careers—a modern style of working multiple part-time, freelance jobs. Many are not trying to stop working altogether. They are trying to reclaim ownership over their personal time.

The shift sits at the intersection of burnout, financial independence, changing definitions of success, and growing discomfort with careers that consume more than they give back.

The question is no longer

whether people can retire early. The bigger question is why so many suddenly want to.

RECALIBRATION OF AMBITION

For decades, retirement in India was tied to age. People worked until their late 50s or early 60s, accumulated savings, collected a pension if fortunate, and then withdrew from active professional life.

Today, a different conversation is taking shape.

The pandemic fundamentally altered how people think about work.

According to Mansee Singhal, Careers Leader India at professional services firm Mercer, the post-pandemic workforce is not abandoning ambition; it is recalibrating what it means.

“The journey from the Great Resignation, through mass layoffs, to quiet quitting reflects a workforce that has been operating under sustained pressure for years. Quiet quitting was not a re-